Lecture : 9

THE SILK ROUTE CONNECTIONS II
TRADE, RELIGION AND CULTURAL INTERACTIONS

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MAIN ARGUMENT

- CRITIQUE OF THE "SILK ROAD" PARADIGM
- RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN BUDDHISM AND MARITIME COMMERCE
- INDIA–CHINA MARITIME BUDDHIST NETWORKS
- SRI LANKA AS A MARITIME BUDDHIST CENTRE
- LONG-TERM TRANSFORMATION OF MARITIME BUDDHIST NETWORKS
- NEW APPROACHES TO THE ‘SILK ROAD’

CHALLENGING THE ‘SILK ROAD’ NARRATIVE

- SEN CRITICISES OVERWHELMING SCHOLARLY EMPHASIS ON THE OVERLAND SILK ROADS. HE FURTHER ARGUES THAT THE EXPRESSION **"MARITIME SILK ROAD"** ITSELF IS HISTORICALLY MISLEADING
- SILK WAS NOT THE PRINCIPAL COMMODITY CARRIED ACROSS THE SEA
- MARITIME TRADE INVOLVED SPICES, PEARLS, INCENSE, CERAMICS, METALS, BEADS AND TEXTILES
- THE TERM GIVES EXCESSIVE IMPORTANCE TO CHINA
- IT UNDERESTIMATES SOUTHEAST ASIA AND INDIAN OCEAN SOCIETIES
- SEN ADVOCATES VIEWING MARITIME ASIA AS A **MULTI-CENTRED COMMERCIAL WORLD**, NOT A CHINA-CENTRED EXTENSION OF THE SILK ROADS

COMMERCE AND RELIGION WERE DEEPLY INTERCONNECTED

One of Sen's strongest arguments is that Buddhism expanded because commercial networks already existed

- MERCHANTS
  - HELPED WITH TRANSPORTATION FOR MONKS
  - FINANCED MONASTERIES
  - SPONSORED RELIGIOUS INSTITUTIONS
  - CIRCULATED RELICS
  - CARRIED MANUSCRIPTS

MONASTERIES

- PROTECTED MERCHANTS
- OFFERED LODGING
- CREATED TRUSTED COMMERCIAL ENVIRONMENTS
- GENERATED DEMAND FOR LUXURY COMMODITIES THROUGH BUDDHIST RITUAL PRACTICES

Thus religion did not merely accompany trade.
It became embedded within commercial exchange itself.

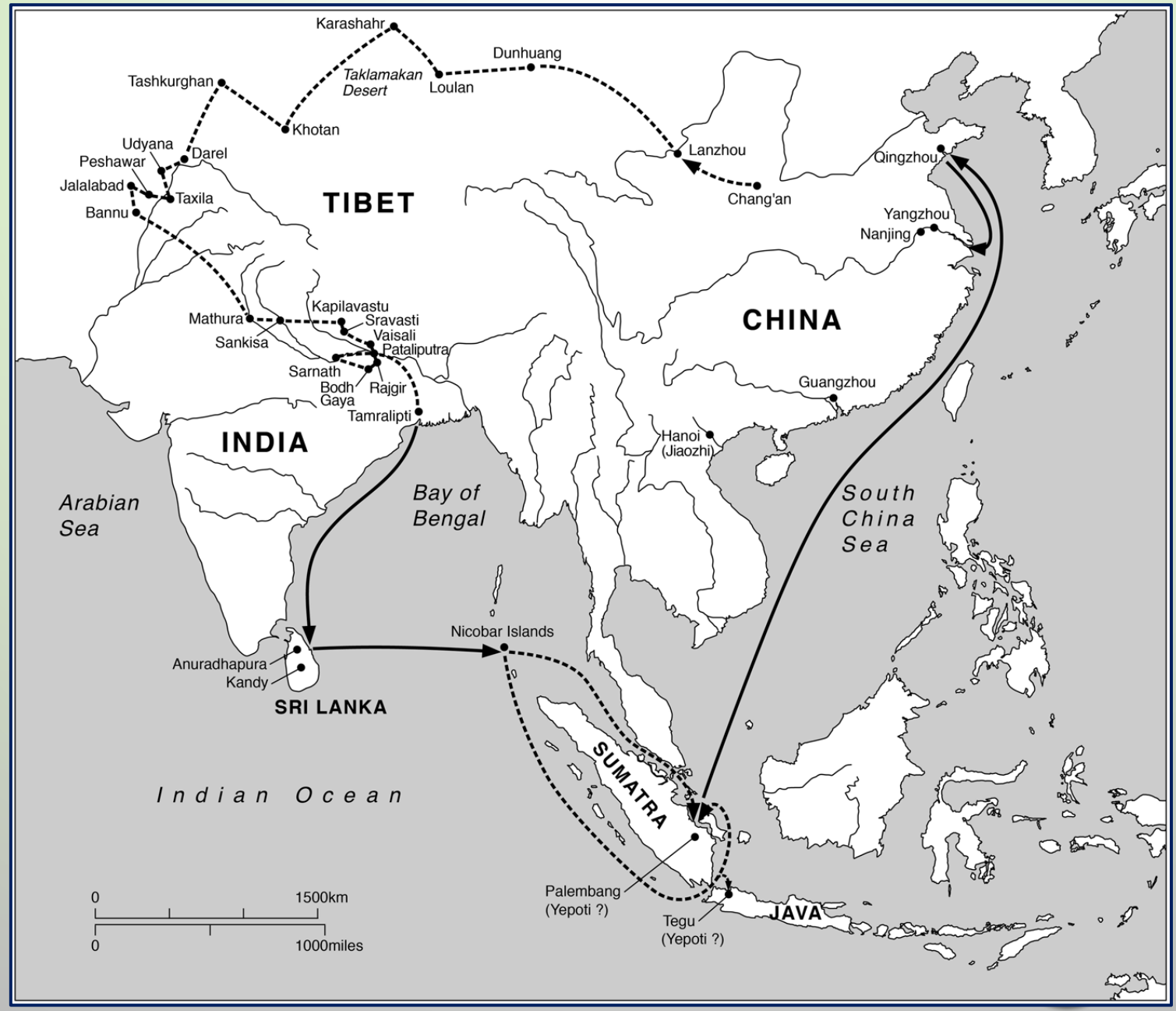
MARITIME SOUTHEAST ASIA WAS INITIALLY A TRANSIT ZONE

Rather than claiming that Buddhism first spread gradually throughout Southeast Asia before reaching China, he argues that during the first centuries CE Southeast Asia functioned largely as a transit zone.

- BEFORE CONTINUING TO CHINA, SHIPS
  - STOPPED
  - CHANGED CREWS
  - REPLENISHED SUPPLIES
- ONLY LATER DID PERMANENT BUDDHIST INSTITUTIONS EMERGE.

- THE ARCHAEOLOGICAL EVIDENCE SUPPORTS THIS INTERPRETATION BECAUSE:
  - EARLY BUDDHIST MONASTERIES ARE ABSENT BEFORE THE FOURTH–FIFTH CENTURIES
  - BUDDHIST INSCRIPTIONS APPEAR RELATIVELY LATE
  - BUDDHIST INSTITUTIONS GROW ALONGSIDE EXPANDING MARITIME COMMERCE.

MARITIME NETWORKS IN SOUTH AND SOUTHEAST ASIA



INDIA–CHINA MARITIME NETWORKS

Sen reconstructs a remarkably cosmopolitan maritime world. Rather than depicting India and China as isolated civilisations, he presents them as linked through continuous movement.

PARTICIPANTS INCLUDED

- INDIAN MERCHANTS
- SOGDIAN TRADERS
- CENTRAL ASIANS
- SRI LANKAN MONKS
- CHINESE PILGRIMS
- SOUTHEAST ASIAN RULERS

RATHER THAN DEPICTING INDIA AND CHINA AS ISOLATED CIVILISATIONS, HE PRESENTS THEM AS LINKED THROUGH CONTINUOUS MOVEMENT.

EXAMPLES INCLUDE

- KANG SENGHUI
- GUNAVARMAN
- BODHIDHARMA
- PARAMĀRTHA
- FAXIAN
- NUMEROUS MERCHANT PATRONS

BUDDHIST NETWORKS IN THE INDIAN OCEAN

SRI LANKA

- PERHAPS THE MOST SIGNIFICANT CONTRIBUTION OF THIS ARTICLE IS ITS REINTERPRETATION OF SRI LANKA.
- MOST HISTORIES DESCRIBE SRI LANKA SIMPLY AS THE CENTRE OF THERAVĀDA BUDDHISM.
- SEN ARGUES THAT SRI LANKA ALSO BECAME
  - A MAJOR MARITIME TRANSIT HUB
  - REPOSITORY OF BUDDHIST RELICS
  - CENTRE OF MAHĀYĀNA TRADITIONS
  - CENTRE OF TANTRIC BUDDHISM
  - DIPLOMATIC ACTOR ACROSS THE BAY OF BENGAL.
- PILGRIMS
  - FAXIAN,
  - VAJRABODHI,
  - AMOGHAVAJRA,
  - AND LATER ATĪŚA
  - ALL TRAVELLED THROUGH SRI LANKA.
- ITS MONASTERIES BECAME INTELLECTUAL CROSSROADS RATHER THAN ISOLATED THERAVĀDA CENTRES.

SRI VIJAYA

- SEN SHIFTS ATTENTION FROM INDIA TO SOUTHEAST ASIA.
- BY THE SEVENTH CENTURY, ŚRĪVIJAYA HAD BECOME
  - A COMMERCIAL EMPIRE
  - EDUCATIONAL CENTRE
  - BUDDHIST UNIVERSITY
  - STAGING GROUND FOR PILGRIMS
- THE CHINESE MONK **YIJING** RECOMMENDED THAT CHINESE MONKS SPEND ONE OR TWO YEARS STUDYING THERE BEFORE TRAVELLING TO INDIA. THIS ILLUSTRATES THAT INTELLECTUAL AUTHORITY WAS NO LONGER MONOPOLISED BY INDIA.
- KNOWLEDGE HAD BECOME DISTRIBUTED ACROSS MARITIME ASIA.

REFLECTING ON THE READINGS

HISTORICAL CONTRIBUTIONS

- **1. CONNECTED HISTORIES**

RATHER THAN WRITING SEPARATE HISTORIES OF INDIA, CHINA OR SOUTHEAST ASIA, SEN RECONSTRUCTS INTERCONNECTED NETWORKS.

- **2. MARITIME HISTORY**

THE SEA IS PRESENTED NOT AS EMPTY SPACE BUT AS AN ACTIVE HISTORICAL ARENA.

- **3. NETWORK THEORY**

IDEAS SPREAD THROUGH NETWORKS RATHER THAN POLITICAL BOUNDARIES.

- **4. ECONOMIC HISTORY**

TRADE AND RELIGION ARE SHOWN AS MUTUALLY REINFORCING RATHER THAN SEPARATE PROCESSES.

- **5. BUDDHIST STUDIES**

LONG-TERM TRANSFORMATION

EVOLUTION OF MARITIME BUDDHIST NETWORKS EVOLVED.

- **EARLY PERIOD**
  - INDIA → CHINA
- **MIDDLE PERIOD**
  - SRI LANKA → SOUTHEAST ASIA
- **LATER PERIOD**
  - THERAVĀDA NETWORKS LINKING SRI LANKA, MYANMAR, THAILAND AND CAMBODIA

- EVEN AFTER OVERLAND BUDDHIST EXCHANGES DECLINED BECAUSE CENTRAL ASIA INCREASINGLY BECAME DOMINATED BY ISLAMIC NETWORKS, **MARITIME BUDDHIST EXCHANGES** CONTINUED INTO THE MODERN PERIOD.

CRITICAL EVALUATION

STRENGTHS

- **EXCELLENT USE OF INTERDISCIPLINARY EVIDENCE**
- INSTEAD OF RELYING ON ONE CATEGORY OF SOURCES, SEN COMBINES
  - ARCHAEOLOGY
  - INSCRIPTIONS
  - TRAVEL ACCOUNTS
  - CHINESE CHRONICLES
  - BUDDHIST BIOGRAPHIES
  - MATERIAL CULTURE

- **STRONG COMPARATIVE FRAMEWORK**
  - RATHER THAN REPLACING OVERLAND ROUTES WITH MARITIME ROUTES, HE ARGUES THEY COMPLEMENTED EACH OTHER.
  - THIS BALANCED INTERPRETATION IS ONE OF THE ARTICLE'S GREATEST STRENGTHS.

- **EXCELLENT USE OF MOBILITY**
- THE ARTICLE DEMONSTRATES THAT
  - PEOPLE
  - OBJECTS
  - TEXTS
  - RITUALS
  - AND IDEAS

ALL TRAVELLED TOGETHER

LIMITATIONS

- **1. HEAVY DEPENDENCE ON CHINESE TEXTUAL SOURCES**

MANY RECONSTRUCTIONS DEPEND UPON FAXIAN, YIJING, AND CHINESE BUDDHIST BIOGRAPHIES.

- **2. LIMITED DISCUSSION OF LOCAL AGENCY**
  - ALTHOUGH SOUTHEAST ASIA EVENTUALLY BECOMES IMPORTANT, EARLY SOUTHEAST ASIANS OFTEN APPEAR AS INTERMEDIARIES RATHER THAN ACTIVE PRODUCERS OF BUDDHIST THOUGHT.
  - RECENT SCHOLARSHIP INCREASINGLY EMPHASISES LOCAL ADAPTATION RATHER THAN PASSIVE RECEPTION.

- **3. MERCHANT COMMUNITIES REMAIN GENERALIZED**
- THE ARTICLE TREATS MERCHANTS LARGELY AS ONE CATEGORY.
- GREATER ATTENTION COULD HAVE BEEN PAID TO THEIR DIFFERENT MOTIVATIONS
  - TAMIL MERCHANT GUILDS
  - ARAB MERCHANTS
  - MALAY TRADERS
  - GUJARATI MERCHANTS

- **4. GENDER IS ALMOST ABSENT**

APART FROM BRIEF REFERENCES TO SRI LANKAN NUNS, WOMEN RECEIVE LITTLE ANALYTICAL ATTENTION.

‘SILK ROADS’: CONNECTING OLD WITH THE NEW

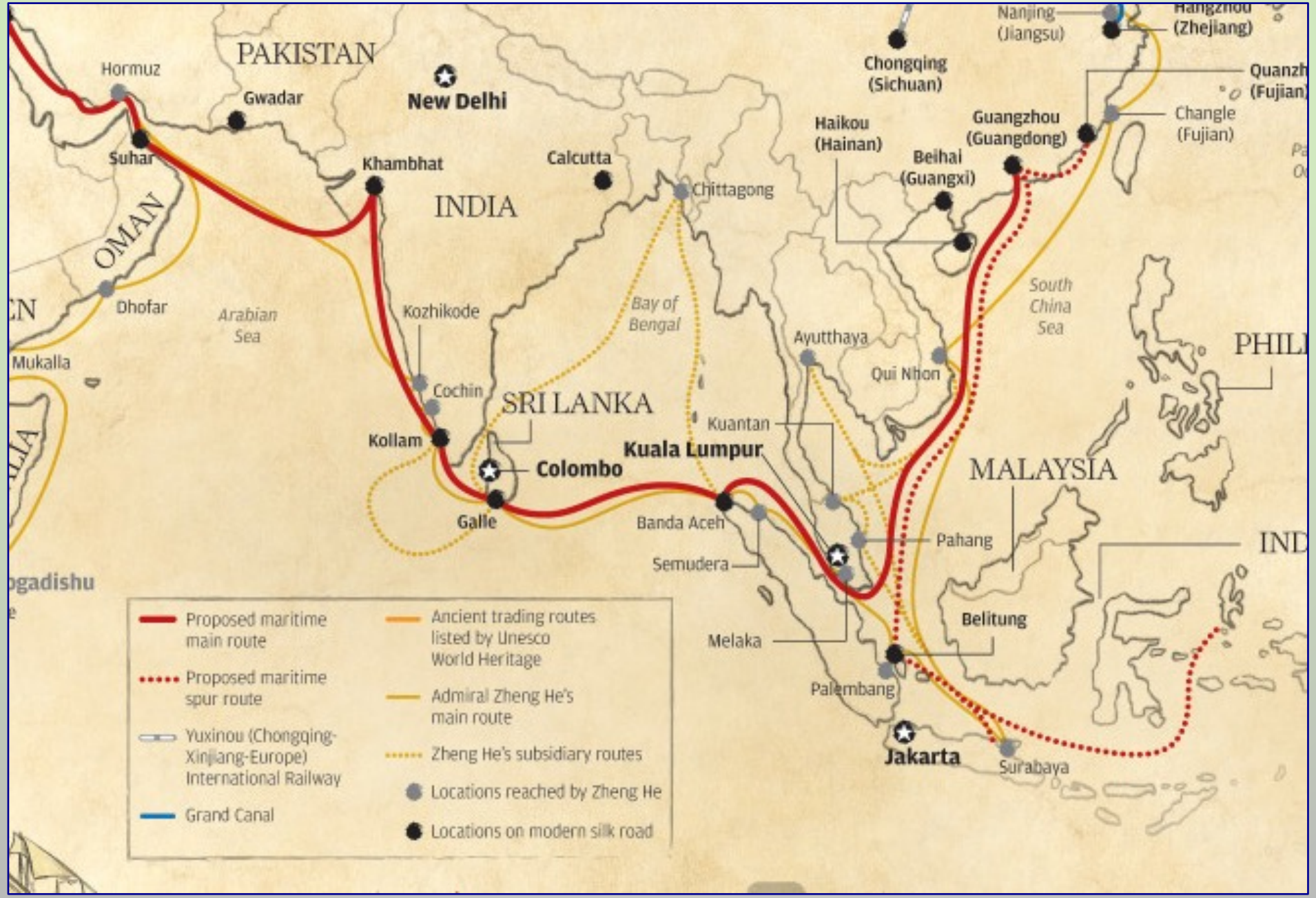
- THE LENSES OF APPROACHING ‘SILK ROUTES/ ROADS’ HAVE CHANGED DRASTICALLY IN THE NEW MILLENNIUM
- MOST IMPORTANT FOREIGN POLICY INITIATIVE BY XI
- CENTRAL ASIA IN FOCUS- DIRECTION OF CHINESE CAPITAL FLOW (CHINESE CONTRACTS WITH KAZAKHSTAN, UZBEKISTAN, TURKMENISTAN, TAJIKISTAN)
- INTEGRATION OF MARKETS
- FEEDING INTO THE NEEDS OF THE CHINESE STEEL AND COAL PRODUCTION- DIRECTED TOWARDS INDUSTRIALISATION OF CENTRAL ASIA

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=KPOWIxnUErM

- INVOLVEMENT OF SOUTH ASIA AND THE WORLD
- WHY INDIA REFRAINED FROM JOINING THE CHINESE PROJECT

HTTPS://WWW.FORBES.COM/SITES/ALYSSAAYRES/2017/05/15/INDIA-OBJECTS-TO-CHINAS-ONE-BELT-AND-ROAD-INITIATIVE-AND-IT-HAS-A-POINT/#2FB60C46B262

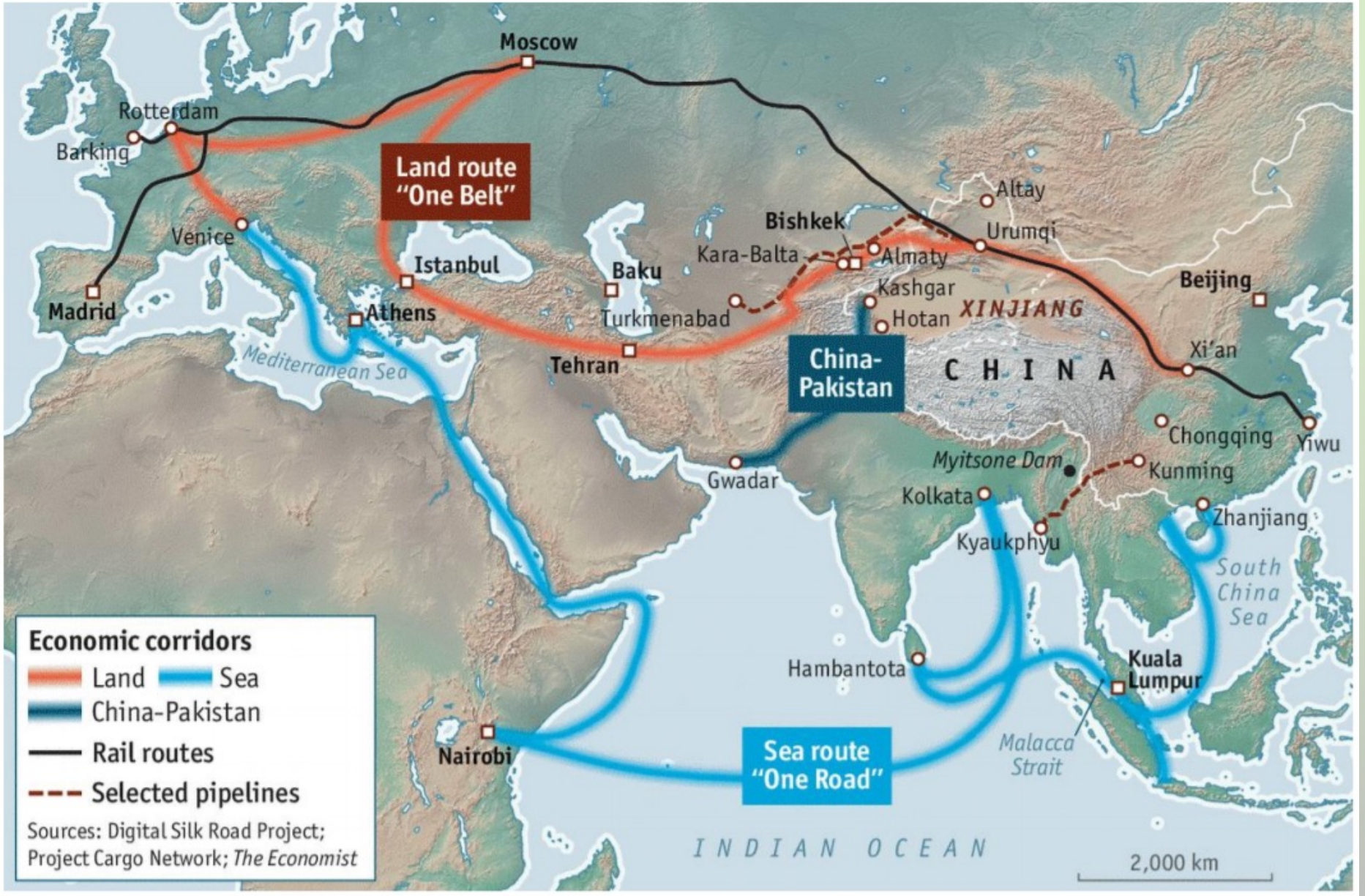
MAPPING OLD ROUTES WITH NEW PROJECTIONS



From OBOR to BRI

Chart 1

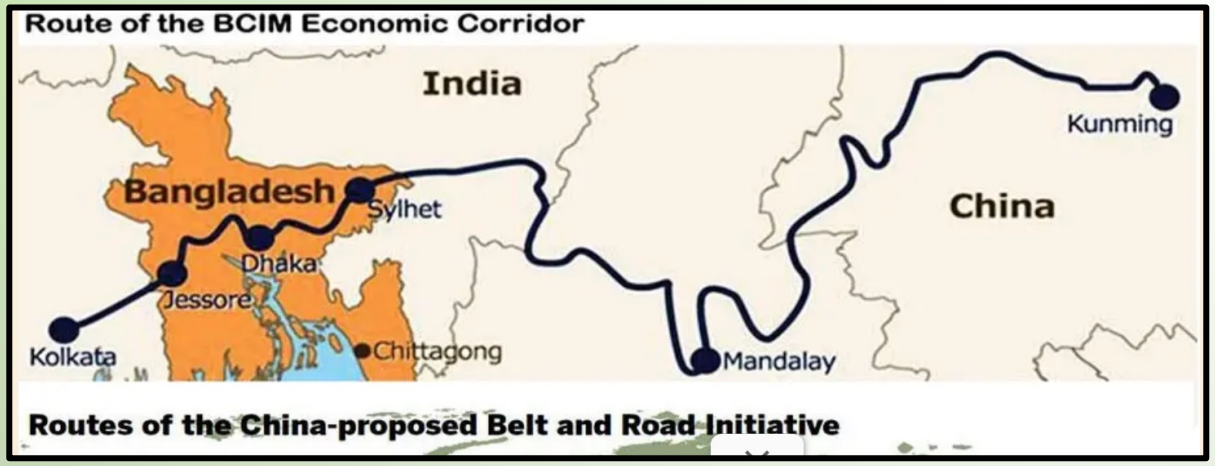
Belt and Road Initiative: Partial Map

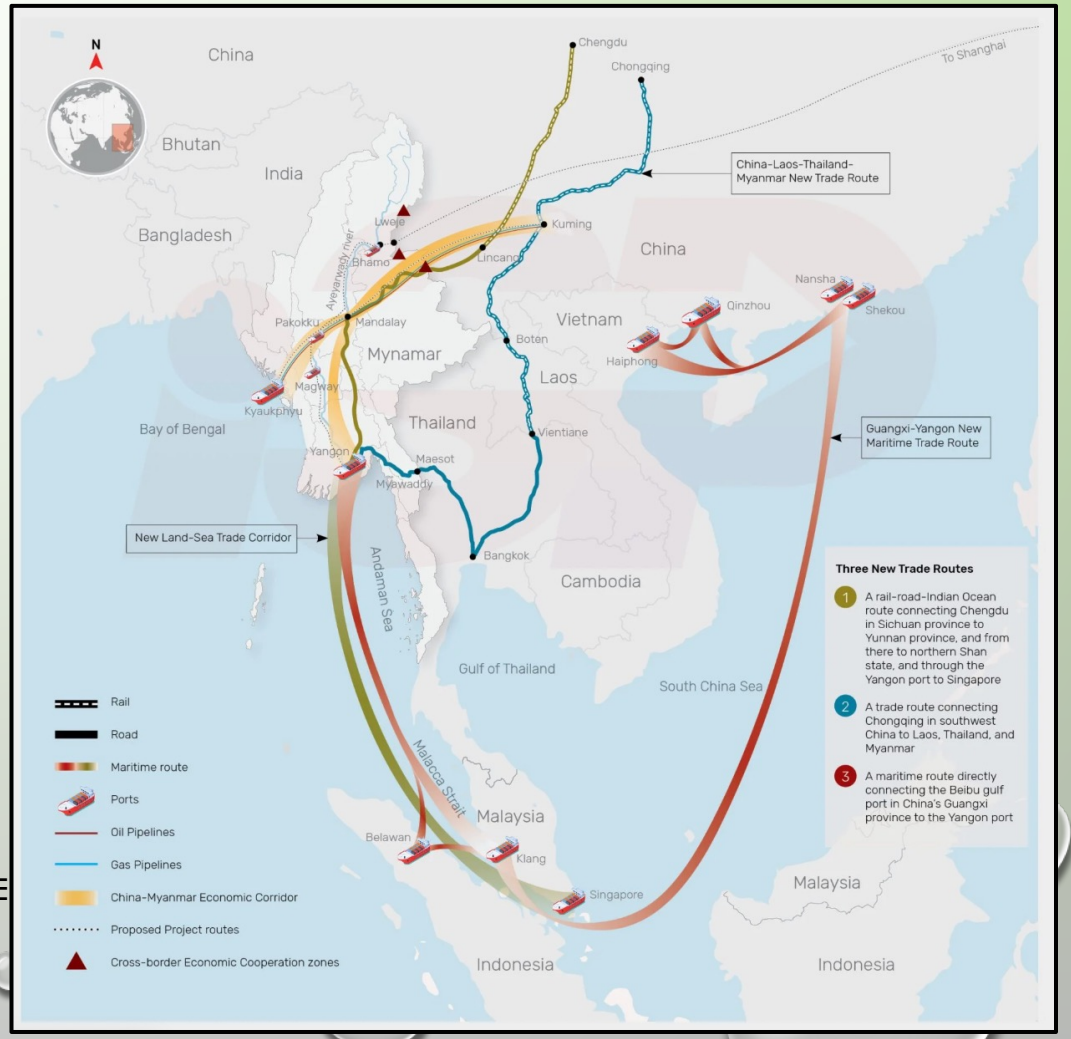


Source: Economist.com

RE-EMERGENCE OF THE SOUTHERN SILK ROUTE

The rhetoric of the South Silk Road has become an inevitable part of political, policy and academic dialogue rethinking ancient Yunnan-Myanmar-India connections through old routes, local trade and human interactions that had never ceased to exist.



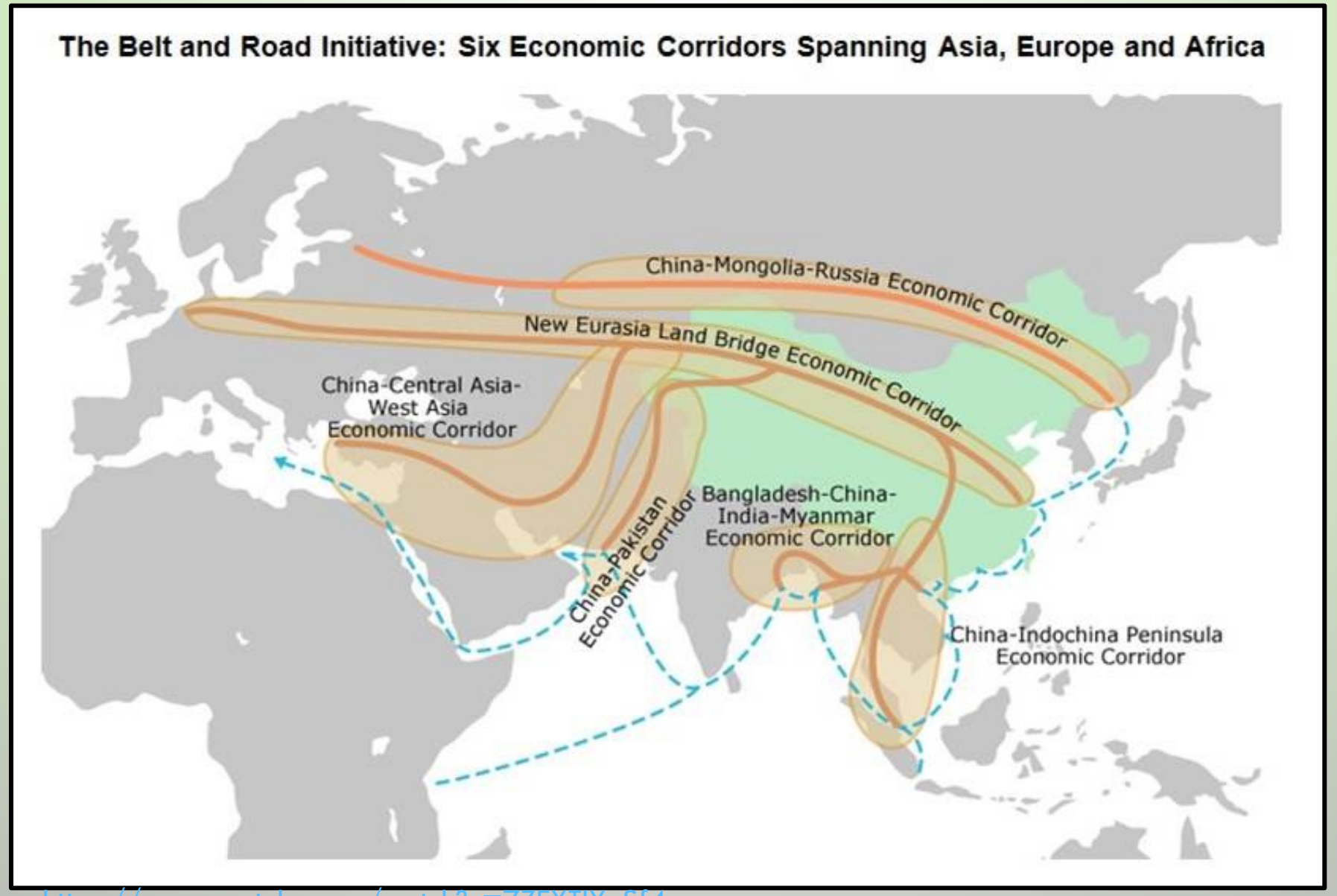


- **THE SOUTHERN SILK ROAD WAS A NETWORK, NOT A SINGLE ROAD:** THE "SOUTHERN SILK ROAD" REFERS TO **OVERLAPPING CORRIDORS** - OVERLAND, RIVERINE, AND MARITIME - RATHER THAN ONE FIXED LINE ON A MAP

- **COLONIALISM RESTRUCTURED RATHER THAN SIMPLY EXPANDED MOBILITY:** THE BRITISH BUILT INFRASTRUCTURE AND INTENSIFIED TRADE, BUT THEY ALSO **DISRUPTED OLDER REGIONAL CIRCULATIONS**, IMPOSED NEW BORDERS, AND RESHAPED THE MEANING OF SPACE

- **MODERN STATES SELECTIVELY USE THE PAST:** PROJECTS LIKE **BRI, ACT EAST,** AND **BCIM** INVOKE HISTORICAL CONNECTIVITY, BUT THEY DO SO IN POLITICALLY STRATEGIC WAYS. THE PAST IS BEING MOBILIZED, NOT NEUTRALLY REMEMBERED

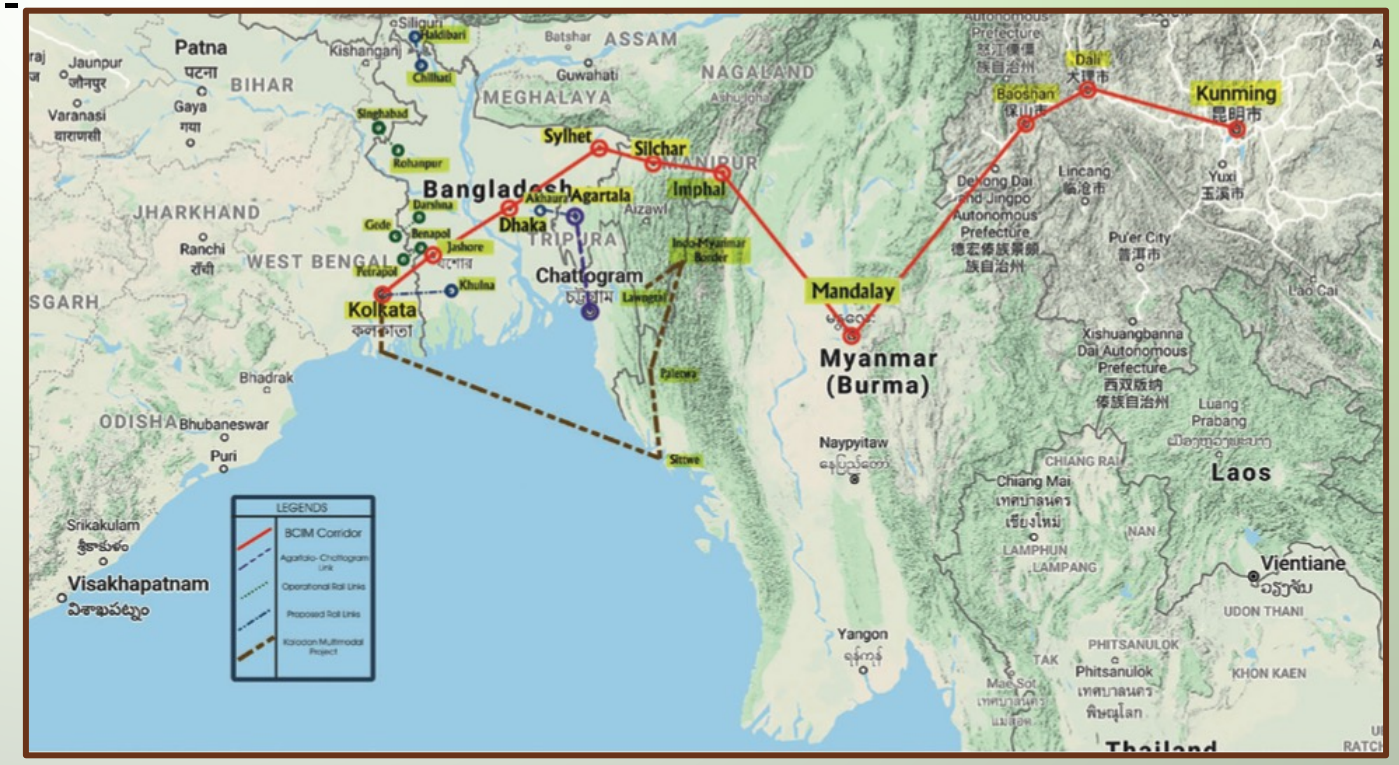
CHINA'S VISION



https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=7ZFXTIYySf4
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ekNvSdDQeoc

MULTILATERAL GROUPINGS IN THE BAY OF BENGAL

- **BIMSTEC** [BAY OF BENGAL INITIATIVE FOR MULTI-SECTORAL TECHNICAL AND ECONOMIC COOPERATION]
- **ASIAN TRILATERAL HIGHWAY** CONNECTING INDIA AND THAILAND THROUGH MYANMAR
- **BCIM** [BANGLADESH-CHINA-MYANMAR-INDIA]
- **BBIN** [BANGLADESH, BHUTAN, INDIA AND NEPAL]



https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Jtx-Fbg1n6g

NEW APPROACHES TO THE STUDY OF THE ‘SILK ROADS’

- FROM "THE SILK ROAD" TO "THE SILK ROADS”
- CONNECTED HISTORIES
- NETWORK THEORY
- MARITIME SILK ROADS
- MOBILITY STUDIES
- GLOBAL HISTORY
- INDIAN OCEAN STUDIES
- RELIGIOUS NETWORKS
- MATERIAL CULTURE
- ENVIRONMENTAL HISTORY
- DIGITAL HUMANITIES AND GIS MAPPING
- COMPARATIVE EMPIRE STUDIES
- INTERDISCIPLINARY SILK ROAD STUDIES

Comparison in Historiography

Earlier Scholarship	**Contemporary Scholarship**
One Silk Road	Multiple Silk Roads
Overland focus	Overland and maritime networks
Trade in luxury goods	Exchange of goods, ideas, religions, technologies, and people
State- and empire-centred	Networks, mobility, and connectivity
National or civilizational histories	Connected and global histories
Static routes	Dynamic, evolving networks
Text-based evidence	Interdisciplinary use of archaeology, material culture, GIS, environmental data, and textual sources
China–Europe axis	Multi-centred Eurasian and Indian Ocean worlds